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"All the News That's Fit to Print"

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, a bit breezy in the morning, mostly sunny, dry, high 62. **Tonight,** mainly clear, dry, low 49. **Tomorrow,** mostly sunny, breezy, dry, high 65. Weather map appears on Page B10.

VOL. CLXXVI .... No. 61,044 © 2026 The New York Times Company WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 21, 2026 Prices in Canada may be higher $4.00



LYNSEY ADDARIO FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Miners bring their children — and often press them into work — as they dig for gold at the Antetezamaro mine and other illegal operations in Madagascar, off Africa.

KYIV IS UNDERCUT AS TRUMP OFFERS DEALS TO MOSCOW

PRESSURE FOR A TRUCE

Embrace of Russia Fits in Plan to Get China in Three-Way Talks

By DAVID E. SANGER

WASHINGTON — He shunted aside a bipartisan law, signed just weeks ago, imposing new tariffs on Russia. He cut a deal to purchase diesel from Moscow. His negotiators agreed on the vague outlines of a deal for much of Lukoil, a battered Russian energy firm. And he called for the replacement of President Volodymyr Zelensky of Ukraine, whose success in taking the fight inside Russia deeply frustrates him.

President Trump's intensifying effort in the past few weeks to rehabilitate Russia and usher President Vladimir V. Putin back into diplomatic society is remarkable for its speed, its characterization of Mr. Zelensky as the primary obstacle to peace, and its brazen denial that Russia is continuing the war that Mr. Trump says he is trying to end.

"Russia, frankly, has been fine on Ukraine," Mr. Trump said on Monday, speaking to reporters outside the White House as he left for a campaign rally. "They haven't been doing much," he said, making no mention of the Russian missiles and jet-powered drones that have been targeting apartment buildings in Kyiv and Ukraine's surviving electricity grid.

In contrast, he said, "We've given a lot to Ukraine. They've given nothing to us. Remember that." He repeated the statement for emphasis. The night before, he wrote on social media that Mr. Zelensky "doesn't want to end this war, and probably never did," because it brought him a flow of cash and arms from Europe, making no mention that Ukraine is fighting for its sovereignty and even survival in a war that it did not start.

Mr. Trump's disdain for Mr. Zelensky is hardly new. Nor is his willingness to give the benefit of the doubt to Mr. Putin, for whom he has often expressed respect and even admiration.

But what is different now is Mr. Trump's increased determination to force a deal on Mr. Zelensky, telling him that holding out to retain occupied portions of the country's eastern provinces is not worth it — and that there is money to be made for Ukraine, as well, if it would only drop its objections to an accord, even one written largely on Russia's terms.

Mr. Trump's special envoy, Steve Witkoff, on Tuesday met the Ukrainian president in Oslo. Jared Kushner, Mr. Trump's son-in-law, participated remotely.

On Wednesday, Mr. Witkoff and

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NEWS ANALYSIS

Centrists Flail Across Europe

Voters Lured to Fringes by Promises of Change

By STEVEN ERLANGER

BERLIN — Centrist parties are in trouble in Europe's largest and most important nations. Anger over low economic growth, high inflation, sizable government debt and poor prospects for the young are feeding protest and populist parties of the far right and far left.

The mass riots in France, which started as protests over underfunded schools, are a shocking example. But the phenomenon has been building for years, with the perceived failure of liberal democracy to make good on its promises of a better future, especially for the young and the salaried working class.

There is a growing perception among many Europeans that traditional parties of the center-left and center-right do not offer real alternatives and are led by an educated elite that has lost its connection to the poor, the workers and the young. Facing rising deficits, expenses and interest rates, governments feel constrained in what they can do to respond.

Instead, many people are supporting parties like the National Rally of Marine Le Pen, leading the polls for the French presidency on the far right, and France Unbowed of Jean-Luc Mélenchon, on the far-left, running second. In Germany, they are turning to the far-right Alternative for Germany and the far-left Die Linke party.

With major elections coming in the next year in four of Europe's most populous states — Spain, France, Italy and Poland — there are significant challenges coming from more extremist parties. Even in Italy, where protests erupted over the weekend, the right-wing prime minister, Giorgia Meloni, faces a former general, Roberto Vannacci, who is

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A Trillion-Dollar Industry Launders Illegal Gold

In Madagascar, Child Miners and Damage to Environment

By JUSTIN SCHECK

BETSIAKA, Madagascar — In an industry riddled with abuse, the world's banks and governments rely on one entity to keep gangsters, warlords and human rights violators from selling gold into the mainstream market.

That group, the London Bullion Market Association, is the self-described "global authority for precious metals." With the power to blacklist companies, the L.B.M.A. is the closest thing the multitrillion-dollar industry has to an international regulator.

Governments rely on the association's stamp as a sign that gold has been mined without human rights abuses, environmental devastation, financial sanctions or criminality. In the most literal sense, the L.B.M.A. sets the gold standard.

But a New York Times investigation found that the association has repeatedly allowed gold into the market that has been mined by criminals, cartel members and children. Refiners lie with impunity about the origins of their gold. The rules are pocked with exceptions and vagaries, and the L.B.M.A. has repeatedly decided not to enforce them.

And in the case of Madagascar, the L.B.M.A. helped change and backdate key paperwork that certified gold as free from abuse.

As prices skyrocketed in recent years and evidence emerged that gold was financing armed groups in Sudan and polluters in the Amazon, the industry perpetuated the

Continued on Page A5

Zelensky Saw Pushing Back As Only Move

By MARIA VARENIKOVA

KYIV, Ukraine — Ukraine has been here before with President Trump. But this time, as the American leader plays down Russian violence and makes it harder for Kyiv to respond, Ukrainian leaders have taken a different tack. They have punched back.

A senior Ukrainian official likened it to a last chance to sound an alarm as a tsunami approaches. Even before the latest blowup with Mr. Trump, things were looking difficult for Ukraine. Daily strikes were ravaging its energy infrastructure and economy. Ukrainian air defenses were depleted. A difficult winter was drawing near.

Then Mr. Trump moved to buy Russian diesel, lifted sanctions on Russia and pressured Ukraine to stop hitting Russian oil refineries. Kyiv began reporting sudden restrictions on a Pentagon-funded satellite internet network, gaps in the sharing of U.S. military intelligence and delays in the delivery of American interceptor missiles. American officials deny any dis-

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Forever on Top
The Knicks raised a championship banner at Madison Square Garden as the N.B.A. season began.

Will Viruses That A.I. Created Cure a Patient?

Trial F.D.A. Authorized Is Already Underway

By CARL ZIMMER

For the first time, scientists say they have used viruses designed by artificial intelligence to treat a human patient.

Researchers announced on Tuesday that they had administered the virus, known as a phage, to a patient suffering from a deadly bacterial infection. Phages attack bacteria, and the hope is that this one will kill the microbes causing the infection.

Radical Numerics, the start-up that created the viruses, posted a technical report about them on its website. But the company declined to provide information about the patient or the doctors running the trial, citing confidentiality requirements. The report has not been peer reviewed or published in a scientific journal. Company officials said the trial had been authorized by the Food and Drug Administration.

"We take our responsibility to protect patient confidentiality and

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Tehran Taunts Trump on Prices As Midterms Could Reset War

By MICHAEL CROWLEY

WASHINGTON — In the run-up to the midterm elections, the Iranian state news media is gleefully chronicling high prices at American gas pumps — and their effect on President Trump's political standing.

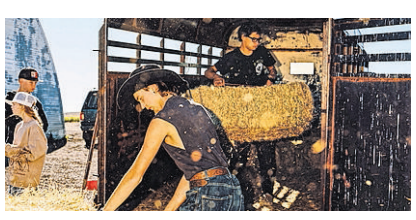
Outlets like Tehran's semiofficial Fars News Agency cite polls reflecting voter anger at Mr. Trump over his conflict with Iran.

Iranian officials are piling on. In an open letter to Americans last month, Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guards Corps wrote that Mr. Trump "keeps on telling Americans that the economy is booming and the prices will soon start coming down," adding, "This is, perhaps, his biggest lie."

A few days earlier, the speaker of Iran's Parliament, Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, mocked a spike in U.S. Treasury bond rates. "We'll return you to 1970s rates, plus high gas prices, diesel shortages and bell-bottoms. Enjoy the nostalgia!" he wrote.

Iran's leaders clearly relish the political damage Mr. Trump has sustained from the conflict he started in late February, even as their own economy faces extreme

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NATIONAL A13-20

Discontent in Farm Country
The war in Iran and tariffs have put economic strain on a core part of the president's coalition. PAGE A13

Charges for Minor Misdeeds
More Texas students ages 10 to 13 are ending up in the justice system for offenses like vaping. PAGE A18

INTERNATIONAL A4-12

Alberta to Stay Part of Canada
Voters in the province rejected separating from the country, aiding Prime Minister Mark Carney's efforts to advance a united nation. PAGE A10

BUSINESS B1-5

Little Relief on Drug Costs
Many Americans are facing rising costs of health care even as President Trump is promoting efforts to cut prices. PAGE B1

Battle Over an Indian Empire
A bitter power struggle has plunged the Tata Group, a 158-year-old conglomerate, into a fight over its future. PAGE B1



FOOD D1-8

Stripped-Down Snack
Danish minimalism reached a new level in a contest to make the best sliced cheese on bread in Copenhagen. PAGE D6

Cereal Is in a Crunch
As more Americans turn away from the snap, crackle and sugar, the industry is trying a health pitch. PAGE D7

SPORTS B6-10

Small Markets Flex Muscles
The Rays-Brewers matchup in the World Series guarantees a first-time champion and upends M.L.B.'s argument for a salary cap. PAGE B7

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A Basketball Pioneer
Harry Lew broke a racial barrier just 11 years after the sport was invented, but his achievement went largely unrecognized. Overlooked. PAGE A24

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Houdini's Death Revisited
A urologist's inquiry into the magician's final days is the latest effort to grapple with outstanding questions about a demise that stunned the world. PAGE C1

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